tests by the Vanniyar community for a separate quota. Telangana's Integrated Household Survey, on the other hand, has made public the data on various populations in the state, but again a caste-wise break-up is missing.

It all boils down to proportional representation. The socialist parties demanding a caste survey argue that reservation to the SC/STs were given based on their population but not so in the case of the OBCs. They say the quotas have to be revised, and a caste census is needed for that. But everyone is aware that this could open a Pandora's box. Siddaramaiah, who started his politics with the Janata parivar, initiated the survey with great promise, but apparently had to hold back the results because of pressure from Congressmen from the dominant Lingayat and Vokkaliga communities.

The BJP brains trust is apprehensive that more Opposition-ruled states could push for such a survey closer to the 2024 election, and that charged-up emotions could hurt its election plans. The party is instead trying to divert the narrative, saying that out of 15,000 notified OBC communities, 9,500 are not getting all the benefits of reservation. In many states in the north, the dominant castes among the backward communities corner a large chunk of the benefits. Union labour minister and OBC leader Bhupender Yadav, though, feels the Modi government's policies will stand it in good stead. "We have ensured the implementation of all social sector schemes without any discrimination on the basis of caste, creed or religion. And the benefits reached the intended beneficiaries without any middleman involved. This has helped all the backward communities," he says.

Meanwhile, the focus is on "restructuring the party framework for better communication", which translates to OBC leaders in prime positions in the focus states. So former JD(U) and Congress turncoat Samrat Chaudhary, an OBC leader and son of veteran Janata parivar leader Shakuni Chaudhary, is the new Bihar state unit chief. In Odisha, the party is relying on general secretary and strategist Sunil Bansal's choice, Manmohan Samal. The OBC politics in the state is expected to heat up by mid-July when the caste survey is expected to be complete. The party is more worried about Bihar where, after Nitish's exit from the NDA, it has had to realign the OBC math. Crucial to this will be the decoupling of the Kushwaha votes from the JD(U) and bringing it back to the NDA fold.

So what is the BJP's position on a caste-based census? Well, ideologically speaking, the big shift in BJP's backward class politics came in 2011 with late Gopinath Munde, an OBC leader himself, making a passionate pitch in Parliament in favour of a caste headcount. The party has come a long way since the Mandal movement of the 1990s, where it had built its electoral fortunes by championing the interests of the upper castes.

In 2018, the Modi government had favoured a caste-based census with then home minister Rajnath Singh making a statement to the effect in Parliament. However, in July 2021, the government backtracked, informing the Lok Sabha that the 2021 census would not have a caste count. That census was delayed by the pandemic and the results are unlikely to come out before the general election.

Today, the party faces a conundrum. A caste-based headcount may lead to sharp reactions among communities. It may also need a rejigging of the quota system, and doing away with the 50 per cent cap on reservations mandated by the Supreme Court. The BJP has to take a call on whether it wants to tread this path. Right now, though, as a top BJP leader put it, "2024 is too close to take this risk". ■

THE REGIONAL FOCUS

How the BJP is tackling the OBC quagmire in crucial states

↘ UTTAR PRADESH
OBC vote: **40%***

- Non-Yadav OBC leaders get a big share of power as ministers, other government appointments
- Reservation for OBCs in government (state as well as Centre) jobs and educational institutions
- Allying with smaller caste-based fronts
- Making inroads with OBC Muslims showcasing Centre's social sector schemes

↘ BIHAR
OBC votes: **47%**

- Kushwaha leader Samrat Choudhary appointed state unit chief to woo the influential OBC community
- Popularising the pro-OBC benefits extended by Centre like reservations, scholarships, grants etc.
- Making inroads with OBC Muslims

↘ ODISHA
OBC vote: **50%**

- OBC leader Manmohan Samal is now state president; gearing up for the BJP government's caste-based survey results expected in July
- OBCs now get 11.2% reservations; BJP is pushing for more to be accommodated with EWS classification
- Promoting the pro-OBC benefits extended by Centre

↘ KARNATAKA
OBC vote: **22%**

- Scrapped the 4% reservation for Muslims; provided reservations for Muslim OBCs in EWS category
- Set up the Sri Narayana Guru Development Board for the welfare of 26 OBC caste groupings, including the Billava-Ediga
- Third largest OBC community Kuruba subdivided for reservations. The Betta (Hill) Kuruba subsect is now designated tribal, work on to add Kadu and Banda Kurubas

↘ MADHYA PRADESH
OBC vote: **50.5%**

- CM Shivraj Chouhan is the biggest OBC leader in the state
- Reservation in local bodies for OBCs faced hurdles, but has now got SC green signal

↘ CHHATTISGARH
OBC vote: **38%**

- Bilaspur MP and OBC leader Arun Sao is the new state unit chief, replacing tribal leader Vishnu Deo Sai
- Relying on pro-OBC benefits extended by Centre to counter the ruling Congress's move to hike OBC reservation in state to 27 per cent

**Estimated OBC numbers of total vote, extrapolated from 2011 census*